

Two Men, One Gospel

Draft sermon version for direct use

Texts: 2 Timothy 4:9-11; Colossians 4:14; Philemon 1:24; Revelation 2:4-5 **Title:** Two Men, One Gospel: Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

Church family, I want to begin with a very small scene in Scripture.

Paul is near the end of his life. He is in prison. The tone of 2 Timothy is heavy, urgent, and personal. Then he writes words that sound almost like a final attendance list:

"Do thy diligence to come shortly unto me: for Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world... only Luke is with me."

Two names.

Two outcomes.

One leaves.

One stays.

And the difference between those two men is the burden of this sermon.

Because Demas and Luke did not begin in different places. They stood near the same apostle. They heard the same gospel. They served in the same work. They lived in the same difficult age. Yet by the end, one has gone after the world and the other remains at Paul's side.

So this is not simply a sermon about an unfaithful man from the first century. This is a sermon about the movement of the human heart.

The deepest spiritual danger is not always open rebellion. Sometimes it is outward usefulness with inward drift. Sometimes it is staying near the work while slowly cooling toward Christ.

That is what makes Demas so sobering.

He does not appear first as a scandal. He appears first as a companion.

Colossians 4:14 says, "Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you."

Philemon 1:24 places Demas among Paul's "fellow labourers."

So Demas is not an outsider. He is not a spectator. He is a worker. He is trusted. He is inside the circle.

He has a good start.

Then 2 Timothy 4:10 tells us the tragedy:

"Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world."

Notice what Paul does not say.

He does not say Demas became openly wicked.

He does not say Demas was caught in some notorious sin.

He does not say Demas lost all religious language.

He says Demas loved something else more.

That is the issue.

Love.

Affection.

Allegiance.

Demas did not leave the work first. He left his love first.

And I think that is one of the most important lines we can carry from this sermon.

Because many believers do not drift through sudden collapse. They drift through quiet reassignment of affection.

As a physician, I think of the difference between an acute event and a chronic disease. Some problems happen suddenly and everyone sees them. Other problems build quietly over time. By the time the symptoms are obvious, the disease has already been working for a long while.

Demas, spiritually, looks like a chronic condition of the soul.

He drifted by degrees.

He stayed near ministry, but he no longer stayed near the center.

That is still possible now.

And it is possible in very respectable ways.

That is what makes this text so uncomfortable.

The world does not only come to the church wearing the face of open rebellion. Sometimes it comes wearing the face of necessity, ambition, caution, and even responsibility.

It says:

Just protect your future.

Just secure your comfort.

Just give the best of yourself to what looks urgent.

Just keep Christ somewhere in the picture, but do not let Him interrupt too much.

That is how many people drift.

In fact, it is one of the most common dangers in a serious Christian life.

Because the world does not only tempt us with obvious wickedness. The world also tempts us with safer things:

- comfort
- recognition
- professional success
- emotional self-protection
- financial security
- admiration

● control

And many of those things are not evil in themselves. That is what makes the temptation subtle. Good things become dangerous when they become ruling things.

Demas loved "this present world," this present age, this present arrangement of values and rewards. He wanted what the age offers.

And that is still the temptation of the church.

The age tells us:

Build more.

Earn more.

Secure more.

Protect yourself more.

Be admired more.

And slowly the soul begins to thin.

Prayer becomes hurried.

The Bible becomes familiar, but not nourishing.

Church becomes attended, but not inhabited.

The schedule stays full, but devotion grows cold.

And let me put it plainly. There is a version of worldliness that can exist inside a very active Christian life.

You can still be useful.

You can still be admired.

You can still be orthodox.

You can still be busy in church.

And Christ can still no longer be first.

Ellen White captures this kind of decline with remarkable accuracy. In *Testimonies for the Church*, volume 5, she warns that a hurried prayer is offered now and then, but there is no real communion with God. That is not the description of a pagan. That is the description of a believer whose inner life has gone weak.

That is Demas.

Now look at the contrast.

"Only Luke is with me."

Those are small words, but they shine.

Luke is called in Colossians "the beloved physician." He was educated. Skilled. Useful. He could have had options. He could have chosen a safer path. He could have disappeared into a more comfortable life when association with Paul became risky.

But he stayed.

When the room emptied, he stayed.

When Paul was old, weakened, and imprisoned, he stayed.

When faithfulness was costly, he stayed.

Ellen White says that the services of Luke, the beloved physician and faithful friend, were a great comfort to Paul. I love that phrase: faithful friend.

That is Luke.

Not flashy.

Not loud.

Not self-promoting.

Faithful.

And there is another reason Luke matters here. Luke did not only remain beside Paul. He also gave the church some of the clearest language about costly discipleship.

Luke records Jesus saying, "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me."

Luke wrote those words.

And then, in Paul's darkest hour, Luke lived them.

He did not merely preserve the call of discipleship. He obeyed it.

He did not merely write about the cost of following Christ. He paid it.

And the church does not only need gifted people. The church needs steady people. It needs believers who are still in the room when things become difficult. Paul says, "Only Luke is with me." In that moment, one faithful disciple became the visible comfort of God to a suffering apostle.

That is why Luke is such a beautiful answer to Demas.

Both men heard the gospel.

Both men knew Paul.

Both men worked.

Both men lived under pressure.

But one loved the present world and the other remained anchored in Christ.

And that is why John 21 matters here. After the resurrection, Jesus does not first ask Peter, Are you stronger now? He asks, "Lovest thou me?" Why? Because love sits underneath endurance. Love sits underneath obedience. Love sits underneath sacrifice.

Now let me widen the sermon from a biography to a church.

In Revelation 2, Jesus speaks to the church at Ephesus. And listen carefully to how He describes them.

He says: I know thy works. I know thy labor. I know thy patience. I know your discernment. I know your endurance.

This is a strong church.

A working church.

A serious church.

An active church.

And yet Jesus says, "Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love."

That is a sobering line.

Because it means activity is not the same thing as affection.

It means being right is not the same thing as being warm toward Christ.

It means a person can keep doing the right things and still lose the center.

You do not have to leave the church to leave your first love.

You can still sing.

You can still teach.

You can still serve.

You can still preach.

You can still attend.

And your heart can still move.

Demas is what Revelation 2 looks like in one human life.

And that should humble all of us, because it means a person can be right in many ways and still need revival.

Ellen White says of the church's decline that gradually believers lost sight of the Saviour and His love. That is always the real problem. When Christ becomes less vivid, other things become more powerful.

So what is the answer?

Jesus gives it in Revelation 2:5:

Remember.

Repent.

Return.

Remember from where you have fallen.

Repent of what has displaced Him.

Do the first works.

That is not a call to become frantic. It is a call to come back to the center.

It is a call to pray again without hurry, to read Scripture not merely to prepare but to commune, and to confess honestly what has moved too close to the throne.

And this is where I want to make an explicitly Adventist turn.

The Sabbath is part of God's answer to the Demas problem.

The Sabbath is not only a doctrine to defend. It is a gift to receive.

Every week the world teaches us to measure ourselves by output, achievement, speed, and gain. Every week we are tempted to believe that worth is produced by striving.

Then Sabbath comes and says:

Stop.

Remember your Creator.

Remember your Redeemer.

Remember that you are more than what you produce.

Remember that relationship is deeper than performance.

In Exodus, the Sabbath says you are not self-created. In Deuteronomy, the Sabbath says you are not a slave. Every Sabbath stands against the lie that your worth comes from what this age rewards.

That is why I want to say it this way: the Sabbath is God's built-in resistance against becoming Demas.

Not a rule to burden us.

A rescue to reorder us.

Ellen White says we are not merely to observe the Sabbath as a legal matter, but to understand its spiritual bearing upon all the transactions of life. That is exactly right.

The Sabbath interrupts:

- identity through achievement
- constant striving
- the slow replacement of God by good things

And the Sabbath recenters:

- relationship over performance
- trust over productivity
- devotion over deliverables

Isaiah says to call the Sabbath a delight. That means the Sabbath is not only about stopping labor. It is about enjoying God again. It is about letting the heart come home.

The problem with Demas was not that he worked. The problem was what he loved while he worked.

That is the question for us.

What is competing with Christ for your deepest affection right now?

What has become too central?

What have you protected more carefully than your communion with God?

What has made prayer feel optional?

What has made the presence of Christ feel secondary?

What have you protected more fiercely than your first love?

And if someone wrote one sentence about your spiritual life five years from now, would it sound more like Colossians 4 or 2 Timothy 4?

Would it say that you remained among the fellow laborers?

Or would it say that you loved this present world?

Would those closest to you say they have seen in you the warmth of Christ, or only the pressure of activity?

Please hear this with hope.

The sermon does not end with Demas.

It also gives us Luke.

Luke stayed.

Luke remained.

Luke was a faithful friend.

Luke shows us that steadfastness is possible.

And more importantly, Christ Himself makes steadfastness possible.

You do not overcome drift merely by fear.

You overcome drift by seeing Christ again as better.

That is why *Steps to Christ* says that when His love fills the heart, duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure. When Christ is first, obedience is no longer empty form. It becomes living response.

So today the call is simple.

Remember.

Repent.

Return.

Ask God to reorder your loves.

Ask Him to warm what has cooled.

Ask Him to make the Sabbath a delight again.

Ask Him to rescue you from religious activity without first love.

And ask Him to make you more like Luke than Demas.

If the Spirit is naming something in you right now, do not explain it away. Do not rename drift as maturity. Do not rename neglect as busyness. Bring it to Christ. He exposes in order to heal. He calls in order to restore.

Because in the end, the issue is not whether we stood near the gospel for a while.

The issue is whether we loved Christ enough to remain.

Luke stayed.

By the grace of God, so can we.

Amen.